Social Security Administration

One-page brief

Priority: 22 of 33 (score 2.7). **FY2026 outlays:** $1,664B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27. Public data only.

Bottom line

SSA pays more benefits than any agency but publishes almost nothing at the payee level. Its error rates are low for retirement benefits and high for Supplemental Security Income (11.6%). The most useful public-data role for SSA is as a supplier: its death records are what other agencies (OPM, PBGC, CMS) are missing when they pay dead people. Approach SSA as a data partner first and a target second.

Exposure

- SSI: $7.3B improper (11.6%). Disability Insurance: $2.3B. (GAO, FY2025)
- PBGC credited a pension plan for 3,479 deceased participants because it did not check SSA's death file, overpaying about $127M (2023).
- GAO found FEHB paying about 400 providers for services dated at least 50 days after their death (2026).

Public data we can use

- **SSA State and county statistics:** beneficiaries and payments by program and county; SSI recipients by state and county.
- **SSA OIG audits and investigations:** representative payee and disability fraud cases.
- **Disability fraud cases** from DOJ and the Cooperative Disability Investigations units, as labeled examples.

Detection plays

1. **Geographic outliers:** counties where SSI or disability rolls and award rates are far above peers after adjusting for age and health.
2. **Facilitator networks:** attorneys, doctors and representative payees who recur across charged disability cases.
3. **Death data gaps (cross-agency):** quantify how much other agencies' payments could be stopped with full death data.

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First prototype

A county-level SSI and disability outlier map, paired with a one-page case for SSA death data sharing built from the OPM and PBGC findings.

Limits

No public payee-level data, and full death data sharing is restricted by law. This brief is mainly a data-access proposal.

Who to take it to

SSA Office of Anti-Fraud Programs, SSA OIG, and Treasury's Do Not Pay.

Sources

- GAO-26-108694: FY2025 improper payments
- PlanSponsor: PBGC overpaid Central States $127M for deceased participants
- GAO-26-108139: FEHB paid deceased and excluded providers
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

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